

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

The current year has been a dodgy one for the men's hockey team. Team India finished a dismal eighth (out of nine teams) in the FIH Pro League and then failed to end its 51-year medal drought at the World Cup. There has been plenty for the Harmanpreet Singh-led team to worry and deliberate about, but then there's no better sporting event than the Asian Games for the team to restore its confidence.

As defending champions and the No. 1-ranked team in Asia, India are the favourites. A top of the podium finish also guarantees a spot at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympic Games. "Everyone believes we dominate the other teams [in Asia], but we don't have the mentality to underestimate a team and think we can win easily," says Harmanpreet Singh. "We need to play with a strong mindset and play our best hockey as a unified team."

Back-to-back bronze medals at the Olympics have meant that there are more eyeballs on the team compared to a decade ago, when noteworthy results were hard to come by. The sport saw an upturn, with Naveen Patnaik's Odisha government investing heavily in the sport. Desired results finally came, as did audience interest. But greater interest also translates to greater criticism, like the team's tendency to flag in tempo and concede goals in the final quarter of a match.

"We know what we did well and what we didn't," says Singh, adding that each performance helps them learn and assures supporters that the team values expectations. "Earlier, we were seen as underdogs, but we have changed that perspective," he says. "You have a responsibility to perform well as you are getting what you want in facilities, which are world-class." Singh and coach Craig Fulton are banking on the depth of the core squad to carry it through the three-week-long campaign in Gifu. The captain adds that rotations in the squad will help the team manage the match schedule.

Acknowledging that his own performance has been "down", Singh says, "When things are not going well, I try to understand my mistakes and be positive." It's not just drag flicks and fitness that get his attention but also the need to "stay connected with players" and lead by example. "I know [the team's recent run] is not to our standard. It has hurt us too," he says. "We believe in *kar ke dikhaiye aur phir bole* [Let our performance do the talking]. We will come back strongly." ■

—Suhani Singh

STICKING TO GOALS

HARMANPREET SINGH, 30

Sport: ***HOCKEY***

Achievement: **Winner of Hockey Asia Cup in 2025**

Claim to fame

Won the Gold medal at the 2022 Asian Games